

Between reform and uncertainty

ISL's commercial revival and policy shifts signal change, yet **instability and execution risks** linger beneath the surface.

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In the last year or so, Indian men's football has developed a habit of arriving late, often after wandering in circles. Out of the Asian Cup race, sliding in FIFA rankings, and with uncertainty over the Indian Super League (ISL) 2025-26 season lingering for six months, chaos had begun to feel like a recurring performance in the country's footballing landscape.

But for the 2026-27 campaign, the grey clouds may finally be giving way to clearer skies: there is serious commercial interest, multiple models on the table, and the season is set to begin on September 4.

The chronology here is pivotal, as several off-field boxes were ticked over the past year to stabilise what happens on the pitch. The enforcement of the National Sports Act, the adoption of the All India Football Federation's (AIFF) constitution, and a viable plan to run the league all suggested an attempt to restore order.

Soon, commercial interest followed. Genius Sports, a London-based sports data and technology company, outbid competitors with a Rs. 2,129 crore offer to become ISL's commercial partner. A club-led financial model was subsequently presented. A league once described as 'commercially impractical' now had multiple takers, with the Federation likely to approve a club-led model for two years.

The decision followed Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya meeting all but one ISL club representative — Jamshedpur FC — on June 8, in the presence of AIFF

president Kalyan Chaubey and former chief Praful Patel.

Under the proposed plan, clubs will reportedly pay over Rs. 1 crore per season into a pool for commercial operations. The AIFF will retain ownership of the league, in line with its constitution, while Genius Sports — earlier a leading contender for the commercial partnership — will now act as a strategic consultant to stakeholders.

"It's a collective decision, the way the management committee and governing council ran the league last season, with five representatives from the managing committee and three from AIFF — the next season will run with a similar structure," a source privy to the developments told *Sportstar*.

"Genius Sports is very much into the scheme of things. The new model has been agreed in principle, and after discussions, the whole thing will be made official."

The developments sound optimistic, but beneath the surface, cracks remain: clubs under financial strain, most teams struggling with empty home venues, and some



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